Almost – A Collection

By Iain S. Thomas, Nora Cooper, Bianca Phipps and Maia Mayor

The Angel of Almost by Iain S. Thomas

. . . . Then I was somewhere else, and it was bright.

A voice said,

"If you'd carried on practicing that song you ***almost*** got right, you would've been great. Bigger than the Beatles."

It continued, "If you'd carried on working on that book you ***almost*** finished, it would've changed the lives of many, many people."

Then it said, "If you'd tried to reach the one you loved just a little bit more, when you ***almost*** had them, your life would've been completely different."

And I asked, "Is this what happens when I die?"

And the voice said, "***Almost***."

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Iain S. Thomas
ISBN: On-line Transcript
http://www.iwrotethisforyou.me/2010/11/angel-of-almost.html
Publisher: I Wrote This For You.com
Date (Month/Year): Posted 11/17/2010

Also Published in

Author: Iain S. Thomas
Book: I Wrote This for You: 2007-2017
ISBN: 978-1449497040
Publisher: Andrews McMeel Publishing
Date: Oct 2018

INTRODUCTION

Almost *isn't a pretty word. In few contexts does it signify something positive. "I* **almost** *got the job, I* **almost** *passed the test." The word* **almost** *doesn't bring about feelings of optimism and cheerfulness. Instead, it brings about feelings of coming so close, yet still being so far -- feelings of defeat, and feelings of inadequacy. It doesn't matter if you* **almost** *. . .*

It's the **almost's** *that make us yearn. It's the* **almost's** *that make us strive. It's the* **almost's** *that destroy us with regret. They're what really tell the story.*

Almost – A Collection containing The Angel of Almost by Iain S. Thomas, I Won't Write Your Obituary by Nora Cooper (excerpts); Almosts by Bianca Phipps, and Perfect by Maia Mayor (excerpts)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I Won't Write Your Obituary by Nora Cooper

You asked if you could call to say goodbye if you were ever
really gonna kill yourself.
Sure, but I ***won't*** write your obituary.

But if you call me, I ***will*** write you letters, messages in
bottles, in cages, in orange peels, in the distance
between here and the moon, in forests and rivers and
bird songs.
I ***will*** write you songs. I can't write music, but I'll find
Rihanna, and I'll get her to write you music if it will
make you want to dance a little longer.
I ***will*** write you 1-800-273-8255, that's the suicide hotline;
we can call it together.

And yeah, you can call me, but I ***won't*** tell you it's okay,
that I forgive you.
I ***won't*** say "goodbye" or "I love you" one last time.
You ***won't*** leave on good terms with me,
Because I ***will not*** forgive you.
I ***will not*** hold your hand steady around a gun.
I ***won't*** write your obituary.

4NG Fanatics

So the answer to your question is "yes".
If you're ever ***really*** gonna kill yourself, yes, please, call me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nora Cooper
ISBN: On-line Transcript Posted 6/29/2015
https://slampoetryforthesoul.wordpress.com/2015/06/29/4/comment-page-1/
Publisher: Slam Poetry for the Soul
Date (Month/Year): Performed at College Unions Poetry Slam Invitational (CUPSI) 2015 in Richmond, VA

Almosts by Bianca Phipps

I have never felt so at ease as the day you called me
precocious.
I have never feared big words, only those that refuse to use
them
And the syllables rolled off your tongue like honey;
I was hooked.
Language became our vein of communication,

And I know that everybody uses language to communicate
but ours was different,

As if in between the letters and the syllables there is a
secret message only we can decipher.

My days were filled with the sound of your voice.
And your nights were littered with the loops of my
handwriting.
We exchanged our favorite words, mine being 'illuminated'
and yours being 'cattywampus';
And our least favorites, mine 'moist' and yours '***almost'***.
And when I asked you why, you said it was because
'***almost'*** held failed potential,
That it represented our ability to be just not good enough,
That we had come to the brink of something beautiful but
fell short so many times, we crafted a word for it.

But even we, with our supposed mastery of the English
language,
were not immune to the shortcomings of our vocabularies.
Words can only help you if you speak them.
I never told you that I loved you.

You never told me that you were dying.
5 easy words that would've shattered our world,

4NG Fanatics

"I love you, I think."
"I have a brain tumor."

You know, still to this day, I don't know all the details
because medical jargon has never fit right in my mouth,
And even now, 5 years later, it feels like an invasion of your
privacy.
But I do know, I have pored over our conversations,
searching for the secret message you certainly tried to
send me,
And I am sorry, but I only almost found it.
Salt water is not good for paper and my tears warped your
words.

After some serious consideration, I've decided to change
my least favorite word,
Because, while 'moist' is gross, 'malignant' is malicious.
'Malignant' is uncontrollable.
Means a phone call in the phrase "He didn't wake up."
'Malignant' is messy and unfair and a thief.
'Malignant' means I never got to say 'goodbye'.
'Malignant' is the cause of ***almost***,
Because you were on the brink of something beautiful but

you couldn't quite reach it and you fell too far.

I am so sorry I wasn't there to catch you.

I hope your heaven is a library and I hope it is void of

'***almost's***'.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bianca Phipps
ISBN: On-line Transcript Posted 8/2/2016
https://slampoetryforthesoul.wordpress.com/tag/button/
Publisher: Slam Poetry for the Soul
Date (Month/Year): Performed at College Unions Poetry Slam Invitational (CUPSI) 2014 in Boulder, CO

Also Published in

Author: Bianca Phipps
Book: Crown Noble
ISBN: 978-1943735792
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date: Aug 2020

TRANSITION

The word "almost" holds failed potential – it represents our ability to be just not good enough.

Where does that start? For Maia Mayor, it echoed through her mother's words which we hear in her poem, Perfect.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

Perfect by Maia Mayor

(In a controlling mother's voice)

Is there something wrong with you?

Where is your devotion to succeed?

I cook and I clean and I don't stop 'til the soles of my feet bleed.

But I'm fine.

I'm perfect.

Be perfect.

Be perfect like me.

Why are you down here?

Why are you down here when you need to be up here?

Up here with the ones who have a promising career

Who listen when information goes in one ear

and doesn't come out the other.

You'll never be up here.

You act as if the act of listening is a crime

or you would have heard me the six hundred and sixty-sixth time

I told you to STOP CHEWING ON YOUR NAILS.

Stop chewing on your nails like a piece of trash.

You can't be trash.
You have to be perfect.
Be perfect like me.

I get up at 5 in the morning every day.
I start my day the same way, worried that I'll collapse
as my bones start to decay from cleaning up your scraps.
Why is your room such a mess?
The clothes go in the hamper.
Not displayed on your bed like your lack of morals.
Not littered on the floor collecting more dust than my
withered expectations.
You disregard my rules with stubborn contempt
in a substandard attempt at teenage rebellion.
But you can't be a rebel.
You're not interesting enough.
You need to obey and say 'yes' and 'okay'
You need to do it with a smile on your less than average
face.
You need to try harder.
Why don't you know how to smile?

4NG Fanatics

You disappoint me.
You never appreciate what I do for you.
You never try to be a winner.
And you never eat your dinner.
You never eat the dinner I consistently provide for you
as I constantly remind you of the life I set aside for you.
That meal doesn't pay for itself.
I don't care if it's ideal, stop telling me how you feel.
You need to eat it.
Eat it all.
Eat it at a reasonable time with a glass of milk.
You need milk.
You need calcium like you need a catalyst for growth.
You'll never grow to be tall.
Be tall like me.
I drink my milk.
Be tall.
Be perfect.
Be perfect like me.

You need to pay more attention.
Stop daydreaming.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Stop staring at the ceiling as if your one redeeming quality

lies hidden in the plaster.

You need to organize your life.

Your life is a disaster

Just like your room.

Just like your future,

Don't give me that look.

I'm just trying to help you.

I'm just trying to love you.

You have to let me love you

so that you can be perfect.

Be perfect like me.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maia Mayor
ISBN: On-line Transcript
https://www.poemhunter.com/poem/perfect-160/
Publisher: Poem Hunter.com
Date (Month/Year): Posted 6/19/2017

Also Published in

Author: Maia Mayor
Book: Get Lit Rising, Pg 8-11
ISBN: 978-1582705774
Publisher: Simon Pulse
Date: Oct 2016

AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier – MS (Full text of this poem only)
KS State Qualifier (Full text of this poem only)

AWARD HISTORY

NE State Qualifier (As a Collection)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY